

doc-divine-omnipotence

Affirms · Theology Proper › Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: high

Statement under examination

God is all-powerful, able to do all that He wills, limited only by His own nature.

Rationale

Pan-canonical lexical network: Hebrew **אל שדי** El Shaddai (H410 plus H7706, 48 occurrences of Shaddai concentrated in Genesis patriarchal disclosures and Job), the verbal force of **יכול** yakol H3201 in Job 42:2 ('you can do all things'), and the verb **פלא** pala H6381 in Jer 32:17 and 32:27 ('nothing is too wonderful or too hard for you'). The Greek network mirrors it: **ἀδυνατέω** adynateo G101 negated in Luke 1:37 ('nothing will be impossible'), **δύναμις** dynamis G1411 ascribed to God across the New Testament, and **παντοκράτωρ** pantokrator G3841 (10 New Testament occurrences, 8 of them in Revelation including Rev 19:6 'the Lord God Almighty reigns'). The anthropomorphic 'God relented' passages (Gen 6:6, Ex 32:14, Jonah 3:10) do not undercut this: the canon's own juxtaposition of 1 Sam 15:11 with 15:29 ('the Glory of Israel will not lie or have regret') forces an accommodation reading.

Reasoning

Verdict: God is all-powerful. He can do everything he wills to do. The only thing he cannot do is act against his own nature, which means he cannot lie or stop being God. The strongest reason from Scripture is the way God names himself. In Genesis 17:1 he tells Abraham 'I am God Almighty,' and on that basis he promises that the elderly and barren Sarah will bear a son. Job 42:2 says 'I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted.' Jeremiah 32:17 prays 'Nothing is too hard for you,' and God himself answers in verse 27, 'Behold, I am the LORD, the God of all flesh. Is anything too hard for me?' The angel Gabriel tells Mary in Luke 1:37 that 'nothing will be impossible with God.' Revelation pictures heaven calling him 'the Almighty' over and over. The strongest counterargument inside the Bible is the set of passages where God seems to change his mind. Genesis 6:6 says the LORD was sorry that he had made humanity. Exodus 32:14 says the LORD relented from the disaster he had threatened. Jonah 3:10 says God relented when Nineveh repented. 1 Samuel 15:11 says God regretted making Saul king. Critics ask, if God knows everything and can do everything, why does he need to change his mind. The verdict handles this tension by reading these texts the way the Bible itself reads them. In the very same chapter where God says he regrets making Saul, 1 Samuel 15:29 says, 'the Glory of Israel will not lie or have regret, for he is not a man, that he should have regret.' The Bible itself puts these two statements side by side. The traditional reading is that God speaks of himself in human terms so that humans can understand him, the way a parent simplifies for a child. God's actions really do respond to human repentance and prayer, but his eternal nature and his power are not threatened by that responsiveness. The doctrine stands on the strongest possible canonical footing.

Denominational landscape

Every major historic Christian lineage confesses that God is all-powerful, and this is among the least contested doctrines in church history. The Apostles' Creed opens with 'I believe in God the Father Almighty,' and that line is sung in the liturgy of nearly every Christian tradition. The early fathers like Augustine and the medieval scholastics like Thomas Aquinas taught that God can do all things that are possible absolutely, meaning anything that does not involve a contradiction. The Catholic Catechism affirms God's almightiness directly. Lutherans confess in the Augsburg Confession Article I that God is of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness. Anglicans in the 39 Articles use the same language. The Reformed

confessions, including Westminster 2.1, call God almighty and most absolute. Methodists in the Articles of Religion repeat the same formula. Anabaptists at Dordrecht confess one eternal almighty God. Pentecostals in the Assemblies of God statement affirm the one true God as the eternal, self-existent Creator. Eastern Orthodoxy uses the title Pantocrator (Ruler of All) liturgically and in iconography. The one in-house evangelical disagreement is open theism, associated with Clark Pinnock, Gregory Boyd, and John Sanders. Open theists do not deny that God is all-powerful. They limit God's exhaustive knowledge of the future, arguing that genuinely free human choices are not yet realities to be known. Classical theists and Calvinists like John Piper have criticized this strongly, but the dispute is over foreknowledge, not power, and open theists are treated as misguided evangelicals rather than as a cult. Process theology, by contrast, denies classical omnipotence outright. Public-record cult or heterodox denials of omnipotence proper include Mormonism, which teaches that God progressed from manhood and is constrained by co-eternal matter and law, and Christian Science, founded by Mary Baker Eddy, which reduces God to abstract Mind and denies the reality of the matter on which power would act. On the bare proposition that God is all-powerful, limited only by his own nature, historic Christianity speaks with one voice.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	Yes
Cult marker if denied	Yes
Would visit if otherwise	No
Would participate if otherwise	No
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

A God who is not all-powerful is not the God of Scripture; the El Shaddai self-revelation of Gen 17:1 inaugurates the Abrahamic covenant on the very basis that God can make the barren bear and the dead live. Pan-canonical lexical demonstration is met. Public-record carriers of explicit denial: open theism (Clark Pinnock, Gregory Boyd, John Sanders) limits exhaustive foreknowledge but generally affirms omnipotence in the classical sense, so it is an in-house evangelical disagreement and not a cult marker. Process theology (Whitehead, Hartshorne, Cobb) denies classical omnipotence outright and places its adherents outside historic Christianity on this point. Mormonism teaches a God who progressed from manhood and is constrained by co-eternal matter and law, a functional denial of omnipotence. Christian Science (Mary Baker Eddy) reduces God to abstract Mind and denies the reality of matter God acts upon. Fruit-vs-precision nuance: most believers cannot articulate the El Shaddai or pantokrator lexical network, but functional confidence in God's power is broadly carried across historic Christian prayer, hymn, and liturgy. The lexical pan-canonical bar is met and cult-marker status holds, but the bar applies to denial of the core proposition (God is not all-powerful), not to disputes over modal scope (can God do the logically contradictory) or to open-theist disputes about foreknowledge.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. classical_theism, open_theism, process_theology

analogia scripturae invoked

Competing lens verdicts

· affirms:

· affirms:

· denies:

Verdict rests on a pan-canonical lemma network spanning both testaments: El Shaddai (H410 plus H7706), yakol (H3201), pala (H6381), dynamis (G1411), dynamai (G1410), dynatos (G1415), adynateo (G101 negated), and pantokrator (G3841). Analogia scripturae is invoked at the 'God relents' tension: 1 Sam 15:29 directly negates the same nacham lemma it affirms in 15:11, forcing the reader to read one of them as accommodation. The grammatico-historical method with the accommodation principle (rooted in Hilary of Poitiers, Chrysostom, and developed extensively by Calvin) handles this honestly. Jeremiah 18:7-10 makes the conditional principle explicit, defusing the Jonah 3:10 and Ex 32:14 cases. The remaining limit, that God cannot act against his own nature (Titus 1:2, 2 Tim 2:13), is built into the proposition itself and is the classical Augustinian-Thomistic clarification.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Gen.17.1 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. יְיָ שַׁדַּי; El Shaddai H410 plus H7706

Force. El H410 = God, mighty one; Shaddai H7706 = Almighty, most powerful. Divine self-revelation to Abram at age 99 inaugurating the covenant of circumcision. The covenant itself is grounded in God's power to do what is naturally impossible (give a son to the barren and elderly)

Job.42.2 · for · genre: wisdom

Key term. יָכוֹל; yakol H3201; כֹּל; kol H3605

Force. yakol = to be able, have power, prevail. Qal imperfect 2ms (continuous capability). kol = all, totality, everything. 'I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted'. Job's final confession after the whirlwind speeches

Jer.32.17 · for · genre: prophecy

Key term. פָּלָא, רָבַד־לְךָ, רָמַמְּ אֶל־פִּי; pala H6381 niphil imperfect

Force. pala = to be wonderful, surpassing, extraordinary, beyond one's power. Negated with kol: 'nothing is too wonderful or too hard for you'. Jeremiah's prayer at the purchase of the field at Anathoth, grounded explicitly in God having made heaven and earth by his great power and outstretched arm

Jer.32.27 · for · genre: prophecy

Key term. פָּלָא, רָבַד־לְךָ אֶל־פִּי; pala H6381 niphil imperfect; basar H1320

Force. God's first-person answer to Jeremiah's prayer of v.17, using the identical pala plus kol construction. 'Behold, I am the LORD, the God of all flesh. Is anything too hard for me?' Divine self-confirmation of the canonical pattern

Luke.1.37 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. οὐκ ἀδυνατήσει παρὰ τοῦ θεοῦ πᾶν ῥῆμα; adynateo G101; rhema G4487; para G3844

Force. adynateo = to be impossible, be unable. Future indicative active 3rd singular, negated. rhema = word, matter, thing. para tou theou = with or from God. Echoes Gen 18:14 LXX (the same phrasing addressed to Sarah). The angel Gabriel's word to Mary at the annunciation

Rev.19.6 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key term. κύριος ὁ θεὸς ἡμῶν ὁ παντοκράτωρ; pantokrator G3841; ebasileusen G936

Force. pantokrator = ruler of all, all-powerful, almighty (from pas plus krato). 10 New Testament occurrences (8 in Revelation, 1 in 2 Cor 6:18). 'The Lord our God the Almighty reigns'. The aorist ebasileusen marks the inauguration of acknowledged universal reign

Gen.18.14 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. הֲבֵיט הוֹיָא אֶלְפִּיהָ; pala H6381 niphil imperfect

Force. 'Is anything too wonderful for the LORD?' Concordance reinforcement: same pala lemma as Jer 32:17 and 27, asked by God himself to Sarah at the announcement of Isaac's birth. The lemma binds the Abrahamic covenant promise to the omnipotence claim

Ps.115.3 · for · genre: psalm

Key term. הַשֵּׁעַ עֲפֹתֵי-שָׁמַיָא לֹא; kol H3605; chaphets H2654

Force. 'Our God is in the heavens; he does all that he pleases'. Predicates divine freedom of action: God's power is exercised exactly along the line of God's will. Concordance reinforcement from the psalter

Matt.19.26 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. παρὰ δὲ θεῷ πάντα δυνατά; dynatos G1415

Force. dynatos = possible, able, powerful. 'With God all things are possible'. Jesus' own dominical statement, addressed to the question of salvation. Concordance reinforcement of the dynamis G1411 lemma family in the gospels

Eph.3.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. τῷ δὲ δυναμένῳ ὑπὲρ πάντα ποιῆσαι ὑπερεκπερισσοῦ; dynamai G1410; hyperekperissou G5238

Force. dynamai = to be able. 'Him who is able to do far more abundantly than all that we ask or think, according to the power that works within us'. Paul's doxology grounds prayer-confidence in divine omnipotence. Concordance reinforcement of the dynamis lemma family in the epistles

Gen.6.6 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropomorphism, anthropopathism

Key term. נָחַם הוֹיָא; nacham H5162 niphil consecutive imperfect

Force. nacham niphil = to be sorry, regret, relent, be moved to pity. 'The LORD regretted that he had made humanity on the earth, and it grieved him to his heart'. Read literally, suggests God responds to outcomes he did not foresee, which would complicate omnipotence. Read as accommodation, describes divine grief over creaturely sin in human terms

Exod.32.14 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropomorphism, anthropopathism

Key term. הערה־לע הוהי סתני; nacham H5162

Force. 'The LORD relented from the disaster he had threatened to do to his people'. After Moses' intercession at the golden calf. Read literally, God changes course; read as accommodation, God's announced judgment was conditional on the people's unrepentance and his eternal will included Moses' intercession

1Sam.15.11 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropopathism

Key term. לואש־תא יתכלמה־יכ יתמתנ; nacham H5162

Force. 'I regret that I have made Saul king'. First-person divine speech of regret. Sits in tension with v.29 of the same chapter, the same lemma both affirmed and denied within 18 verses

1Sam.15.29 · for · genre: narrative · figures: anthropopathism

Key term. סתני אלו הקשי אל לארשי תצנ סג; nacham H5162; shaqar H8266

Force. 'And also the Glory of Israel will not lie or have regret, for he is not a man, that he should have regret'. Same nacham lemma as v.11, here directly negated, with the explicit reason that God is not a man. The canon's own resolution: 'God relented' language must be read as accommodation

Jonah.3.10 · complicates · genre: prophecy · figures: anthropopathism

Key term. מיהלאה סתני; nacham H5162

Force. 'God relented of the disaster that he had said he would do to them, and he did not do it'. Nineveh's repentance is the conditional. Read with 1 Sam 15:29 and the earlier chapter where God explains the conditional principle (Jer 18:7-10), this is the announced principle, not a change in the divine mind

Jer.18.8 · for · genre: prophecy · figures: anthropopathism

Key term. הערה־לע יתמתנו; nacham H5162

Force. 'If that nation, concerning which I have spoken, turns from its evil, I will relent of the disaster that I intended to do to it'. God himself states the conditional principle: divine 'relenting' is the announced response to repentance, built into the prophetic word from the start. Resolves the apparent complication

Titus.1.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ὁ ἀψεудὴς θεός; apseudes G893

Force. apseudes = not lying, truthful, incapable of falsehood. 'God, who never lies'. The classical limit on omnipotence: God cannot act against his own nature. Paul names a specific impossibility that is no defect in power but a perfection of nature

2Tim.2.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἀρνήσασθαι γὰρ ἑαυτὸν οὐ δύναται; arneomai G720; dynamai G1410

Force. 'He cannot deny himself'. Paul names the second classical limit: God cannot act against his own being. Directly anchors the 'limited only by his own nature' clause of the proposition

Concordance lemmas traversed

H410, H7706, H3201, H6381, H3605, H2654, H5162, H8266, H1320, G101, G4487, G3844, G3841, G936, G1411, G1410, G1415, G893, G720, G5238

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Augustine, City of God Book XXI ch. 7, and Thomas Aquinas, Summa Theologica I Q.25 A.3 (CCEL) · affirms · verified

“Aquinas: 'God is called omnipotent because He can do all things that are possible absolutely'. The patristic and scholastic tradition limits omnipotence to non-contradictories, not to defect of divine power”

catholic_magisterial · Apostles' Creed line 1; Catechism of the Catholic Church, paragraphs 268 to 274 on 'The Almighty' · affirms · unverified

“The Apostles' Creed opens 'I believe in God the Father Almighty'. The Catechism teaches God's omnipotence as universal, loving, and mysterious, manifest supremely in creation and the resurrection of Christ”

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article I, Of God (bookofconcord.org) · affirms · verified

“One Divine Essence, eternal, without body, without parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness, the Maker and Preserver of all things. Lutheran confession of divine omnipotence in the opening article”

anglican · 39 Articles, Article I, Of Faith in the Holy Trinity · affirms · unverified

“There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body, parts, or passions; of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness. Anglican confession of God's omnipotence at Article I”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith 2.1, Of God and of the Holy Trinity · affirms · unverified

“There is but one only living and true God, who is infinite in being and perfection... immutable, immense, eternal, incomprehensible, almighty, most wise, most holy, most free, most absolute. Reformed confession of omnipotence”

methodist · United Methodist Articles of Religion, Article I, Of Faith in the Holy Trinity (umc.org) · affirms · verified

“There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body or parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness; the maker and preserver of all things. Methodist confession of omnipotence at Article I”

anabaptist · Dordrecht Confession of Faith (1632), Article 1, Of God and the Creation of All Things · affirms · unverified

“We believe in one eternal, almighty, and incomprehensible God, the Father, Son, and Holy Ghost. The Anabaptist tradition confesses divine omnipotence with the historic Christian church”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, Truth 2, The One True God · affirms · unverified

“The one true God has revealed Himself as the eternally self-existent 'I AM', the Creator of heaven and earth and the Redeemer of mankind. Pentecostal confession of the omnipotent self-existent God”

eastern_orthodox · OCA, The Orthodox Faith, on God the Father (oca.org) · affirms · verified

“God may certainly be said to exist perfectly and absolutely as the one who is perfect and absolute life, goodness, truth, love, wisdom, knowledge, unity. Orthodoxy uses the title Pantocrator (Ruler of All) of God”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/genesis/17-1.htm>

“Gen 17:1 EI H410 plus Shaddai H7706, divine self-revelation at the inauguration of the covenant of circumcision. EI Shaddai = God Almighty, most powerful”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/job/42-2.htm>

“Job 42:2 yakol H3201 (qal imperfect 2ms, continuous capability) plus kol H3605 (totality). 'I know that you can do all things and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted'”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/jeremiah/32-17.htm>

“Jer 32:17 pala H6381 niphal imperfect negated with kol: 'nothing is too wonderful for you'. Same construction at v.27 in God's first-person answer”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/luke/1-37.htm>

“Luke 1:37 adynateo G101 future indicative active 3s, negated, with rhema G4487 and para tou theou. 'Nothing will be impossible with God'. Echoes Gen 18:14 LXX”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/revelation/19-6.htm>

“Rev 19:6 pantokrator G3841 (8 of 10 NT occurrences in Revelation). 'The Lord our God the Almighty reigns'. Title of God's universal rule in the apocalyptic vision”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/hebrew/7706.htm>

“Shaddai H7706, 48 Hebrew Bible occurrences, concentrated in Genesis (patriarchal disclosure) and Job (wisdom dialogue on divine power)”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/greek/3841.htm>

“pantokrator G3841, 10 NT occurrences (8 in Revelation, 1 in 2 Cor 6:18). 'The all-ruling'. NASB consistently renders 'Almighty', KJV occasionally 'Omnipotent’”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/hebrew/5162.htm>

“nacham H5162 niphal: 'to be sorry, repent, relent'. Used of God in Gen 6:6, 6:7, Ex 32:14, 1 Sam 15:11, 15:35, Jonah 3:10, Jer 18:8. The same lemma is negated of God at 1 Sam 15:29”

supports · category: patristic_archive · https://ccel.org/ccel/aquinas/summa/summa.FP_Q25_A3.html

“Aquinas, Summa I Q.25 A.3: 'God is called omnipotent because He can do all things that are possible absolutely'. Things that are contradictory are not possibilities and lie outside omnipotence”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/>

“Augsburg Confession Article I: 'One Divine Essence, eternal, without body, without parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness, the Maker and Preserver of all things’”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“UMC Articles of Religion Article I: 'There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body or parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness; the maker and preserver of all things’”

supports · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://www.oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/doctrine-scripture/the-symbol-of-faith/god>

“OCA: God is the perfect and absolute one whose existence and attributes transcend human categories. Orthodoxy uses Pantocrator (Ruler of All) liturgically and in iconography”